

Definition of e-commerce

E-commerce is an abbreviation used for electronic commerce. It is the process through which the buying, selling, dealing, ordering and paying for the goods and services are done over the internet is known as e-commerce. In this type of online commercial transaction, the seller can communicate with the buyer without having a face to face interaction.

Definition of e-business

Electronic Business, shortly known as E-business, is the online presence of business. It can also be defined as the business which is done with the help of internet or electronic data interchange i.e. is known as E-business. E-commerce is one of the important components of E-business, but it is not an essential part.

E-business is not confined to buying and selling of goods only, but it includes other activities that also form part of business like providing services to the customers, communicating with employees, client or business partners can contact the company in case if they want to have a word with the company, or they have any issue regarding the services, etc. All the basic business operations are done using electronic media.

Key Differences Between e-commerce and e-business

The points presented below are substantial so far as the difference between e-commerce and e-business is concerned:

- 1.E-Commerce is buying and selling of goods electronically whereas E-Business not only includes buying and selling but it also includes CRM(customer resource management), ERM(enterprise resource management), etc.
2. E-commerce has an extroverted approach that covers customers, suppliers, distributors, etc. On the other hand, E-business has an ambivert approach that covers internal as well as external processes.
3. E-commerce uses the internet to connect with the rest of the world. In contrast to E-business, the internet, intranet and extranet are used for connecting with the parties.
- 4.E-Commerce involves commercial transactions whereas E-Business involves commercial as well as non-commercial transactions.
5. E-commerce requires a website that can represent the business. Conversely, E-business requires a website, Customer Relationship Management and Enterprise Resource Planning for running the business over the internet.
- 6.E-Commerce is part of e-business whereas E-Business includes E-Commerce.

⇒ What is E-commerce?

~~Lecture~~

Lecture-2

20.07.2020

Ans: E-commerce (Electronic Commerce) is the use of ^{the} internet, the web, and mobile platforms to conduct business through digitally enabled commercial transactions between and among organization and individuals.

⇒ Difference between E-commerce & E-business

Feature	E-Commerce	E-Business
1. Core <u>Meaning</u>	Buying and selling goods for or services online.	Digitally managing all internal and external company operations
2. Boundary <u>Reached</u>	Reaches outside the comp. to connect with customers and suppliers.	Stays inside the company to run internal systems and daily work.
3. Exchange of value	Always involves money or financial transactions.	Does not require a financial exchange or money transfer
4. Scope	A narrower concept (it is a subset of e-business)	A broader concept (it encompasses e-commerce entirely)
5. Main target Audience	Connects with external buyers and sellers directly.	Connects internal employees, departments and operations
6. Primary Goal	Focused on revenue generation and online sales	Focused on improving operational efficiency and workflow.

7. Technology Used	Uses the public internet, web, and mobile platforms	Uses internal work networks, intranets, Enterprise system (ERP)
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Q. Why Study E-commerce?

⇒ Technological Shift: E-commerce technology is fundamentally different and significantly more powerful than any commercial technology that preceded it.

Commercial Transformation: It introduces structural changes to how commerce operates globally, altering traditional retail and supply models.

Q. Characteristics of Traditional Commerce?

To understand why E-commerce is revolutionary, the points below contrast it with the key features that defined Traditional commerce:

⇒ Consumers as Passive Targets: Consumers are treated as passive ~~income~~ recipients of marketing messages and mass products pushed by sellers without much direct interaction or feedback. Example: Watching a billboard on a highway — anyone absorb the message as a spectator without any way to click, question or interact on the spot.

⇒ Mass-Marketing Driven: Marketing relies heavily on ~~board~~ mass-media broadcasting. Example: Printing a flyer for a local bakery and distributing it to thousands of households without the info^{of} whether residents buy baked goods or not.

⇒ Sales-Force Driven: Operations depend heavily on physical sales staff to interact with customers. Example: Buying a suit at a physical shop where salesman talks to buyer in person and convinces him to buy that product.

⇒ Fixed Prices: Prices are predetermined by merchants with limited dynamic adjustments. Example: Buying shoes in a shop with 500 BDT price tag that buyer cannot bargain or negotiate lower.

⇒ Information Asymmetry: Merchants possess significantly more information about product quality, true cost and availability than consumers do. Example: Buying a used car where the dealer knows the engine has hidden problem but buyer does not.

Eight Unique Features of E-Commerce Technology

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1. Ubiquity: Technology is available everywhere, anytime, creating a "market space" that replaces physical location constraints.
E-Commerce is accessible everywhere at all time. ~~Consumer~~ Consumer can browse online stores 24 hours a day from their home, workplace or mobile phone without visiting physical shop.
2. Global Reach: Technology reaches across national boundaries to connect with customer.
E-Commerce technology breaks down geographic barriers. A merchant can sell goods or services to ~~by~~ buyers in different ~~countries~~ countries like local customer.
3. Universal Standards: there is ~~no~~ one uniform set of internet standards shared globally across platforms.
E-Commerce ~~stands~~ system runs on a single set of shared technology standards defined by the internet. Because systems worldwide use identical technical rules, different software, payment gateways,

4. Information Richness: Detailed, multimedia-rich information combining text, audio and video is delivered to the user.

E-commerce offers an engaging shopping environment by combining images, text descriptions, video demonstrations and audio. This helps consumers to evaluate the quality of that product.

5. Interactivity: Technology enables two-way communication between buyers and sellers.

E-Commerce platforms allow active user engagement. Consumers can reach for options, ask questions via live chatbots, leave product ratings and feedback.

6. Information Density: The total amount and quality of information available to all market participants increases rapidly while costs decline.

E-Commerce makes market information vast, accurate and cheap to access. Buyers can easily perform real-time price comparisons with minimal effort.

7. Personalization and Customization: Messages and products can be adjusted according to individual user preferences and behavior.

Online platforms can dynamically adapt marketing content and recommendations to match an individual's personal search history and purchase records. Sellers can also offer options to customers.

8. Social Technology: Technology enables user-generated content and social network sharing.

E-Commerce encourages consumers to create their own content, such as unboxing videos, photo reviews etc. Users can share experience and ^{can} give ratings also.

Types of E-Commerce

E-Commerce is classified either by the market relationship or by the technology platform used for the transaction.

1. Business-to-Customer (B2C): Online businesses sell products, services, or digital content directly to individual buyers. That means a company opens a virtual storefront where normal buyers browse items. Example: Buying clothes, books or any products directly from Amazon.

2. Business-to-Business (B2B): Businesses sell goods, raw materials or services to other

businesses online. Here companies use digital networks to trade supplies in bulk, manage inventory and coordinate ~~procurement~~ purchasing with partner firms. It represents the largest type of e-commerce by dollar volume.

Example: A smartphone maker purchasing microchips in bulk from an electronic components market place.

3. Consumer-to-Consumer (C2C): Individual consumers sell goods or services directly to other consumers using an online third-party platform. A digital platform acts as a mediator or auction host helping regular people list their used or homemade items so other individuals can buy them. Example: Selling a used laptop on eBay, renting a room on Airbnb.

4. Mobile - E-Commerce: (M-Commerce): Commercial transaction conducted over wireless networks using handheld mobile services. Instead of using a desktop computer consumers use mobile apps or mobile browsers on smartphones to shop, book trips and pay for services. Example:
• Ordering takeout food, booking a ride or pay bills.

5. Social E-Commerce: Transactions enabled and driven by social media networks and online social relationship. Social media platforms integrate shopping tools - such as 'Buy' buttons market place sections that allows users to buy item directly from feeds.

Example: Purchasing a product directly through Facebook marketplace.

6. Local - E-Commerce: E-Commerce focused on engaging consumers based on their current location. Online services use location data to connect nearby shoppers with local physical stores, through digital deals and local pickups.

Example: Buying a local restaurant discount voucher

E-Commerce Lecture Notes: Business Models and Concepts

1. Introduction to E-Commerce Business Models

- **Core Concept:** A business model is a planned set of business processes and activities designed to generate a profit within an identified market.
- **Business Model vs. Business Plan:**
 - A **business model** serves as the central operational blueprint for generating revenue and creating value.
 - A **business plan** is a formal, written document outlining the business model in detail, including execution schedules, budgets, market analysis, and the competitive environment.
- **Role in E-Commerce:** An e-commerce business model explicitly leverages the unique capabilities of digital technologies—namely the Internet, the Web, and mobile applications—to deliver its value proposition.

2. The Eight Key Elements of a Business Model

Every viable business model must answer eight fundamental questions:

Value Proposition

- **Central Question:** *"Why should the customer buy from you?"*
- **Definition:** Outlines how a company's product or service directly fulfills customer needs and why a buyer will choose it over alternative options.
- **Key Advantages in E-Commerce:**
 - **Personalization and Customization:** Tailoring offerings to specific user preferences.
 - **Reduction of Search and Discovery Costs:** Allowing customers to find items and compare prices faster and more affordably.
 - **Convenience:** Managing transaction execution and direct product delivery.

Revenue Model

- **Central Question:** *"How will the business earn money?"*

- **Definition:** Also termed the financial model, this outlines the exact mechanism through which the company generates revenue, captures profits, and produces a superior return on invested capital.

Market Opportunity

- **Central Question:** *"What marketplace do you intend to serve, and what is its size?"*
- **Definition:** Refers to the total revenue potential within a firm's target marketplace.
- **Marketplace:** An online area of commercial exchange unconstrained by physical or temporal boundaries.
- **Strategic Consideration:** Market opportunity is typically divided into realistic market niches to determine the financial opportunity available to a single firm.

Competitive Environment

- **Central Question:** *"Who else occupies your intended marketplace?"*
- **Definition:** The existing landscape of competitors selling similar products or operating within the same marketplace.
- **Factors to Analyze:**
 - Number of active competitors.
 - Market share and size of competitors.
 - Profitability of competitors.
 - Direct competitors (identical products) vs. indirect competitors (substitutable products).

Competitive Advantage

- **Central Question:** *"What special advantages does the business bring to the marketplace?"*
- **Definition:** Achieved when a firm can produce a superior product or bring goods to market at a lower price point than competitors.

- **Key Sources:**

- **First-Mover Advantage:** Gaining early market share and brand loyalty before others enter.
- **Asymmetry:** Access to unique knowledge, patents, or financial resources that competitors lack.
- **Leverage:** Applying existing operational advantages to adjacent, newly targeted markets.

Market Strategy

- **Central Question:** *"How do you plan to promote your products or services to attract your target audience?"*
- **Definition:** The systematic plan detailing how the firm will enter the target market, gain visibility, and convert prospects into customers.
- **Execution:** Relies on digital marketing tactics such as search engine marketing, social media campaigns, content marketing, and affiliate networks.

Organizational Development

- **Central Question:** *"What types of organizational structures within the business are necessary to carry out the business plan?"*
- **Definition:** The structural roadmap defining the company's internal divisions, job roles, reporting hierarchies, and business procedures.
- **Importance:** Early-stage companies require structural growth over time, transitioning from a single founder to distinct functional departments (e.g., shipping, marketing, customer support).

Management Team

- **Central Question:** *"What kinds of experiences and background are important for the company's leaders to have?"*
- **Definition:** The individuals directly responsible for executing the operations and making the model work.
- **Importance:** Gives immediate credibility to outside investors. A competent management team possesses deep market-specific knowledge and the agility to adapt or pivot the business model when market conditions change.

3. Categorizing E-Commerce Revenue Models

E-commerce businesses primarily rely on five major methods to generate revenue:

Advertising Revenue Model

- **Mechanism:** A website or application provides valuable content or services to build a large or highly targeted audience, then sells advertising space to third-party merchants.
- **Key Metric: Stickiness**—the capacity to keep users on-site and retain their attention.
- **Examples:** Meta (Facebook), Yahoo.

Subscription Revenue Model

- **Mechanism:** Customers pay an ongoing, recurring fee (monthly or annually) for access to premium content, services, or ongoing deliveries.
- **Freemium Variant:** Basic functionality or limited content is provided free of charge, while advanced features or ad-free experiences require a paid subscription.
- **Examples:** Netflix, Spotify, eHarmony, *Consumer Reports Online*.

Transaction Fee Revenue Model

- **Mechanism:** The firm receives a commission, flat fee, or percentage for facilitating, enabling, or executing an exchange between buyers and sellers.
- **Examples:** eBay (seller fees/commissions), E*Trade (brokerage fees per trade).

Sales Revenue Model

- **Mechanism:** Companies generate revenue directly through the sale of physical merchandise, digital content, or discrete services to customers.
- **Examples:** Amazon (physical and digital goods), Birchbox (curated product deliveries).

Affiliate Revenue Model

- **Mechanism:** A site steers its visitors to partner merchants via referral links and collects a commission or percentage on any resulting sales or lead conversions.
- **Examples:** Product review platforms, lead-generation directories, MyPoints.

4. Classifying E-Commerce Business Models

- **Basis of Classification:** E-commerce business models are primarily categorized by **market relationship**—identifying the entities involved in the transaction:
 - **Business-to-Consumer (B2C):** Businesses selling directly to individual consumers.
 - **Business-to-Business (B2B):** Businesses transacting with other business entities.
- **Business Model vs. Technology Platform:** A business model is an economic architecture, whereas a technology platform (such as desktop, mobile commerce/m-commerce, or connected smart devices) is the technical medium through which the business model operates.

5. Major Business-to-Consumer (B2C) Business Models

Portal

- **Characteristics:** Offers integrated search capabilities alongside a consolidated package of content, news, communication tools, and entertainment to act as a general gateway to the Web.
- **Revenue Streams:** Heavily dependent on display/search advertising, alongside subscriptions and transaction referral fees.
- **Types:** General portals (e.g., Yahoo, MSN) versus specialized vertical portals ("vortals") focused on niche subjects.

E-tailer (Online Retailer)

- **Characteristics:** An online merchant that sells physical or digital products directly to consumers.

- **Primary Variations:**

- **Virtual Merchants:** Pure-play online retailers with no physical storefronts (e.g., Amazon).
- **Omnichannel / Bricks-and-Clicks:** Established physical retailers that also run robust e-commerce operations (e.g., Walmart, Macy's).
- **Manufacturer-Direct (D2C):** Producers selling goods directly to end users, cutting out middlemen (e.g., Dell).
- **Catalog Merchants:** Retail operations transitioned from traditional mail-order catalogs to online web channels.

- **Revenue Model:** Sales revenue.

Content Provider

- **Characteristics:** Focuses on the production, distribution, and syndication of intellectual property and digital content, including news, video, music, photography, and text.
- **Revenue Streams:** Subscriptions, pay-per-view/pay-per-download, advertising, and affiliate referral links.

Transaction Broker

- **Characteristics:** Processes transactions that are traditionally executed in person, via telephone, or through independent agents.
- **Core Value:** Reduces transaction friction and simplifies booking/trading by providing an automated online interface.
- **Revenue Model:** Transaction fees and commissions.
- **Examples:** Online travel agencies (Expedia), online financial brokers (E*Trade).

Market Creator

- **Characteristics:** Establishes a digital platform where buyers and sellers can discover one another, list items, browse offerings, negotiate terms, and determine prices.
- **Distinction:** Unlike transaction brokers, market creators do not act as agents for the parties; they provide the digital environment and infrastructure for buyers and sellers to interact directly.
- **Revenue Model:** Listing fees, access fees, and transaction commissions.

- **Examples:** eBay, Uber, Airbnb.

Service Provider

- **Characteristics:** Sells or provides online services, professional expertise, cloud software capabilities, or data processing rather than tangible products.
- **Revenue Streams:** Service fees, ongoing subscriptions, freemium upgrades, and ad placements.

Community Provider (Social Network)

- **Characteristics:** Cultivates a digital space where users with shared interests, backgrounds, or social circles can communicate, publish user-generated content (UGC), and interact.
- **Modern Expansion:** Modern community providers increasingly integrate commercial tools, enabling peer-to-peer buying and selling directly within the social ecosystem.
- **Revenue Streams:** Hybrid model combining high-volume targeted advertising, premium subscriptions, transaction fees, and affiliate referral commissions.
- **Examples:** Meta (Facebook), LinkedIn, Reddit.

Slide 17: Raising Capital

- **Title: Raising Capital**
- **Core Idea:** How new e-commerce startups get the money they need to launch and operate before they become profitable.

- **Key Funding Sources on the Slide:**

- **Seed Capital / Bootstrapping:** Using personal savings, credit cards, or borrowing from friends and family to build the first prototype or website.
- **Incubators & Accelerators:** Organizations (like Y Combinator or TechStars) that provide small seed funding, office space, and business mentorship in exchange for a small percentage of equity.
- **Angel Investors:** Wealthy individuals who invest their own personal money in early-stage startups (usually during early rounds like Seed or Series A).
- **Venture Capital (VC) Firms:** Professional investment firms that manage pooled funds from institutions and invest large sums into high-growth, scalable startups.
- **Commercial Bank Loans:** Traditional debt financing, though less common for early tech startups due to lack of physical collateral.

Slide 18: Crowdfunding

- **Title: Crowdfunding**

- **Core Idea:** Using the Internet and social platforms to collect small amounts of money from a large pool of ordinary people (the "crowd") rather than relying solely on traditional banks or venture capitalists.
- **Primary Types of Crowdfunding:**
 1. **Donation / Donor-Based:** People give money to support a cause, personal project, or disaster relief with no financial return (e.g., *GoFundMe*).
 2. **Rewards-Based:** Contributors pledge money in exchange for a future perk, tiered reward, or early copy of the product once manufactured (e.g., *Kickstarter*, *Indiegogo*).
 3. **Equity Crowdfunding:** Backers invest money in exchange for actual ownership (shares or equity) in the startup. In the US, this was popularized by regulations under the JOBS Act (e.g., *Wefunder*, *StartEngine*, *Republic*).

- **Key Benefits:**

- **Market Validation:** Proves whether real customers actually want the product before mass production begins.
- **Wider Reach & Inclusivity:** Gives female and minority founders, as well as businesses outside traditional tech hubs (like Silicon Valley), direct access to capital.

Maintenance, Repair, and Operations (MRO)

- **Definition**

- **Meaning:** Supplies consumed during the production process that do not become part of the final product and are not central to the firm's core output.
- **Classification:** Commonly categorized in business commerce as **indirect goods**.

- **Examples by Category**

- **Consumables:** Cleaning products, laboratory materials, and everyday office supplies.
- **Industrial Equipment:** Heavy machinery components such as pumps, compressors, and valves.
- **Plant Upkeep & Maintenance:** Spare parts, gaskets, lubricants, and repair tools.
- **Workplace Assets:** Computers, light fixtures, and office furniture.

Key Advantages of E-Commerce

- **Lower Overhead Costs:** Avoids expenses tied to physical retail spaces, such as store rent, heavy building insurance, and large on-site sales teams.
- **24/7 Availability:** Allows customer purchases around the clock from any device, removing physical store hours and travel constraints.
- **Equal Market Reach:** Provides small merchants and startups direct access to a worldwide audience, rivaling the visibility of large corporations.
- **Better Margins & Cheaper Transactions:** Eliminates middlemen (disintermediation) and automates paper-based order processing, lowering transaction fees and protecting profit margins.
- **Convenience & Comparison Shopping:** Enables consumers to evaluate prices, features, and reviews instantly across multiple stores using search engines and shopbots.
- **Self-Service Support:** Lets shoppers manage account details, track packages, and resolve issues independently, which saves time for customers and reduces labor costs for merchants.

- **Mass Customization:** Leverages customer purchase profiles and behavioral data to personalize recommendations and customize physical or digital goods to individual buyer tastes.
- **Enterprise Collaboration:** Connects suppliers, manufacturers, and distributors through digital networks to streamline supply chains and enable just-in-time replenishment.

Key Drivers of E-Commerce - Google Gemini

Key Drivers of E-Commerce

- **Digital Convergence**
 - **Core Concept:** Interconnectivity of modern digital devices.
 - **Impact:** Enables various hardware and software platforms to communicate, share data, and process transactions seamlessly.
- **Ubiquitous Access ("Anytime, Anywhere, Anyone")**
 - **Core Concept:** 24/7 market availability.
 - **Impact:** Removes the limitations of physical store hours and geographic boundaries, allowing transactions to occur on-demand from any connected device.
- **Organizational Restructuring**
 - **Core Concept:** Flattened corporate hierarchies and operational decentralization.
 - **Impact:** Empowers frontline staff with digital tools to handle complex tasks and decisions that previously required intermediate management oversight.
- **Cost and Margin Pressures**
 - **Core Concept:** Intensified global market competition.
 - **Impact:** The widespread availability of competing products and services forces companies to adopt e-commerce channels to lower operational overhead, automate workflows, and protect shrinking profit margins.
- **Demand for Mass Customization**
 - **Core Concept:** Shift toward consumer-tailored offerings at scale.
 - **Impact:** Modern consumers expect personalized goods and experiences, requiring businesses to deploy agile, digitally managed supply chains and interactive storefronts to fulfill custom orders on a mass-market level.

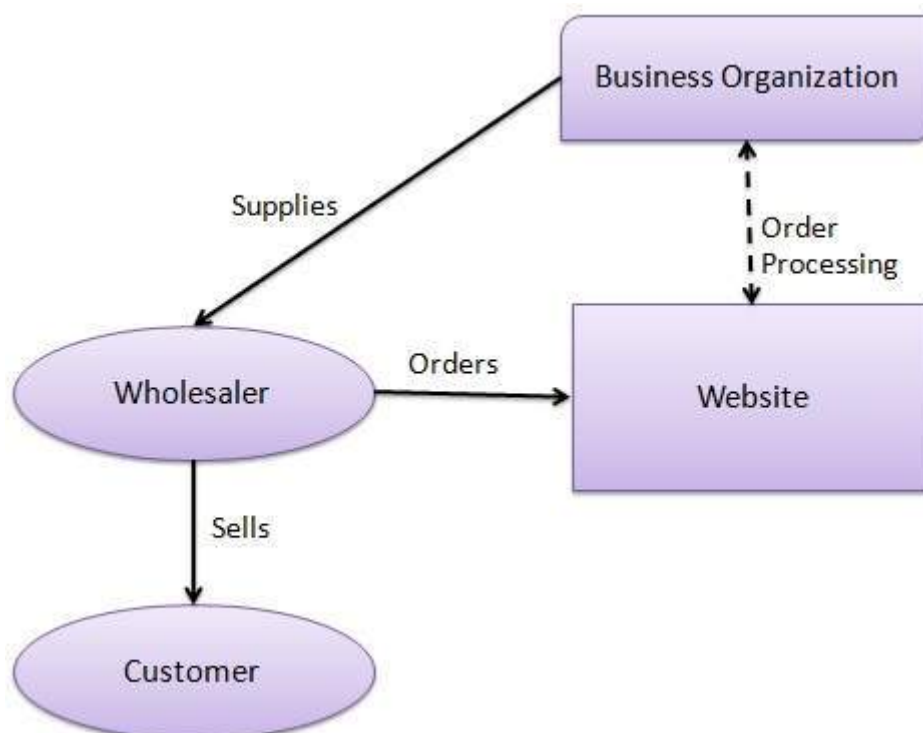
E-Commerce - Business Models

E-commerce business models can generally be categorized into the following categories.

- Business - to - Business (B2B)
- Business - to - Consumer (B2C)
- Consumer - to - Consumer (C2C)
- Consumer - to - Business (C2B)
- Business - to - Government (B2G)
- Government - to - Business (G2B)
- Government - to - Citizen (G2C)

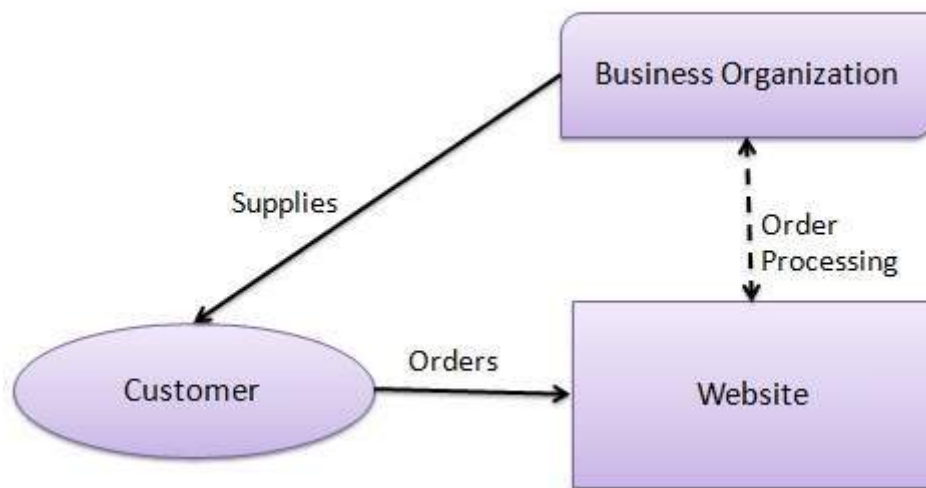
Business - to - Business

A website following the B2B business model sells its products to an intermediate buyer who then sells the product to the final customer. As an example, a wholesaler places an order from a company's website and after receiving the consignment, sells the endproduct to the final customer who comes to buy the product at one of its retail outlets.



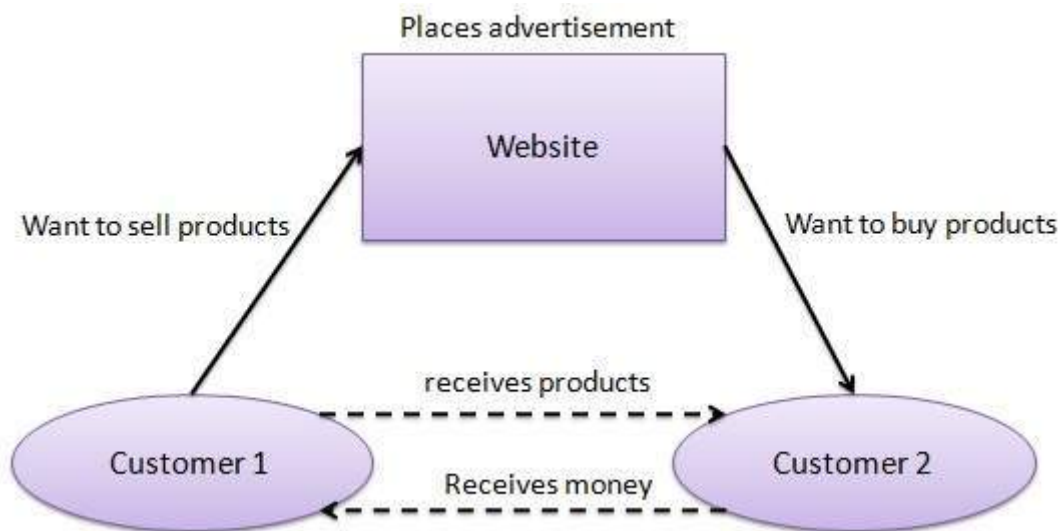
Business - to - Consumer

A website following the B2C business model sells its products directly to a customer. A customer can view the products shown on the website. The customer can choose a product and order the same. The website will then send a notification to the business organization via email and the organization will dispatch the product/goods to the customer.



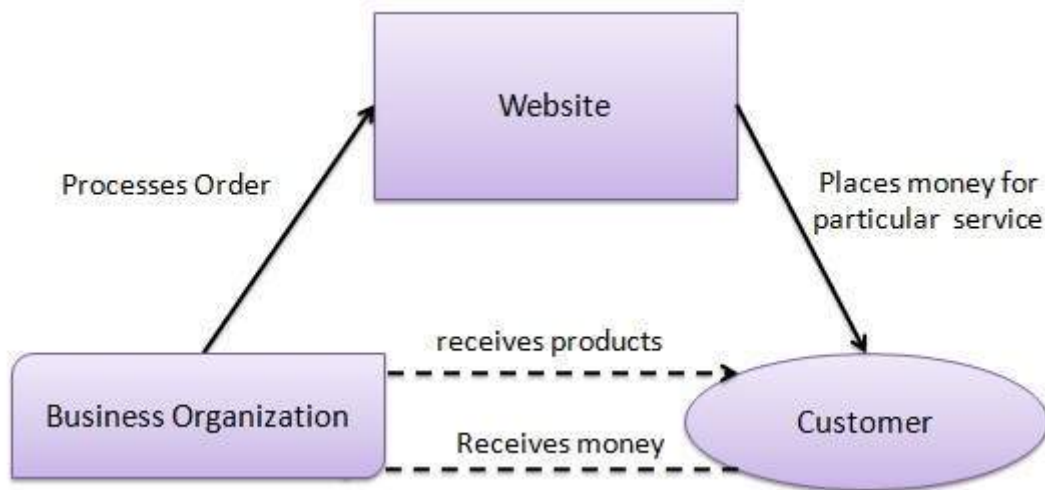
Consumer - to - Consumer

A website following the C2C business model helps consumers to sell their assets like residential property, cars, motorcycles, etc., or rent a room by publishing their information on the website. Website may or may not charge the consumer for its services. Another consumer may opt to buy the product of the first customer by viewing the post/advertisement on the website.



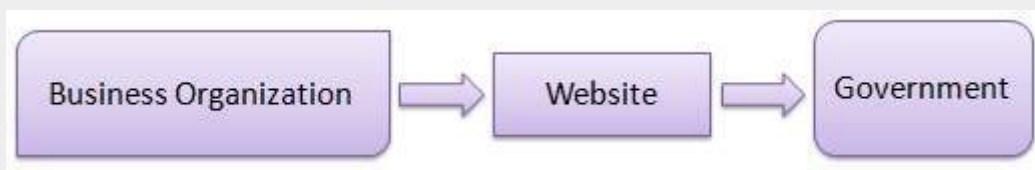
Consumer - to - Business

In this model, a consumer approaches a website showing multiple business organizations for a particular service. The consumer places an estimate of amount he/she wants to spend for a particular service. For example, the comparison of interest rates of personal loan/car loan provided by various banks via websites. A business organization who fulfills the consumer's requirement within the specified budget, approaches the customer and provides its services.



Business - to - Government

B2G model is a variant of B2B model. Such websites are used by governments to trade and exchange information with various business organizations. Such websites are accredited by the government and provide a medium to businesses to submit application forms to the government.



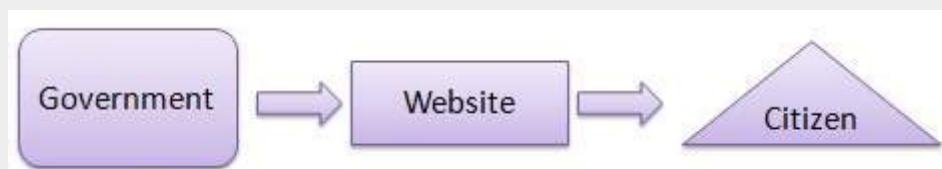
Government - to - Business

Governments use B2G model websites to approach business organizations. Such websites support auctions, tenders, and application submission functionalities.



Government - to - Citizen

Governments use G2C model websites to approach citizen in general. Such websites support auctions of vehicles, machinery, or any other material. Such website also provides services like registration for birth, marriage or death certificates. The main objective of G2C websites is to reduce the average time for fulfilling citizen's requests for various government services.



A decorative vertical bar on the left side of the slide. It features a textured, wood-like background with large, stylized currency symbols: a Euro symbol (€) at the top, a Yen symbol (¥) in the middle, and a Dollar symbol (\$) at the bottom. Interspersed among these symbols are vertical columns of binary code (0s and 1s).

Key Protocols Accessible on the Web

- **E-mail** - the protocol for e-mail is **Simple Mail Transport Protocol, or SMTP**
- **HTTP** - **Hypertext Transfer Protocol** makes possible transmission of hypertext over networks
- **VoIP** - **Voice over Internet Protocol** makes it possible to place a telephone call over the Web

A decorative vertical bar on the left side of the slide. It features a brown background with a grid of binary code (0s and 1s) in a lighter brown color. Overlaid on this grid are three large, stylized currency symbols in a golden-yellow color: a Euro symbol (€) at the top, a Yen symbol (¥) in the middle, and a Dollar symbol (\$) at the bottom.

The Search Engine

A search process begins with a search engine:

a Web site or a database, along with the tools to generate that database and search its contents for “keywords” that describe what you’re looking for.



Tips for Search Engine Optimization

- General keywords are nowhere as good as specific keyword phrases
- Check the Web site of the competition for ideas
- Think of what visitors would search for in the page you're optimizing
- Include the most important keyword phrases in heading tags on your page
- Finalize the list of keyword phrases for the pages you optimize
- The title tag of your page is the most important factor to consider
- Visitors as well as search engines read your pages by looking at keywords to see what you have to offer
- Many people have a false impression that good metatags are all that is needed to achieve good listings in the search engine
- There are two metatags that can help in listing your Web site: meta keywords and meta descriptions



Key Terms for Internet Literacy (*cont'd*)

- **File transfer protocol (FTP)** is a standard protocol that allows you to copy files from computer to computer
- **Telnet** is a basic Internet protocol that allows you to log on to a computer and access files from a remote location as if they were local files
- **Bulletin board systems (BBS)** is a computer-based meeting and announcement system that allows local people to exchange information free of charge. A BBS generally has a simple interface to the Internet for users to access services like e-mail and NetNews.